

6 April 2025

Dear reader,

This research memo, which starts on the following page, was written during my undergraduate studies as an assignment in my final-year technical communication class. This paper was made for the purpose of practicing writing, and the prompt for the assignment was as follows:

Assume that you work for a real or made-up company and your title is Research Engineer. The Chief Technology Officer (CTO) of your company has asked you to investigate a topic and provide a 4+ page research memo outlining key research of interest and making a research-supported recommendation for our company.

I decided to take the route of making up a company for this assignment. Thus, the names of all people (besides mine), the name and details of the application, and the company circumstances discussed in the memo are all fictitious. Any resemblance to existing people, applications, or companies is unintended and coincidental.

With that being said, I give my thanks to my professor and peers who provided invaluable feedback on how to improve the clarity and style of my writing. I had a wonderful time researching and writing about technology-enabled abuse, and I hope you enjoy reading.

Best,
Sophie Chen

MEMO

Date: 6 April 2025

To: Erin Park, Chief Technology Officer

From: Sophie Chen, Research Engineer

Subject: Recommendations for Revising a Location-sharing Feature to be Resistant to Technology-Enabled Abuse

FOREWORD

Our company has decided to introduce a location-sharing feature into our photo-centric instant messaging app, 200OK. Because this feature is the first location-sharing feature to be implemented by our company, I was asked to evaluate how our feature may impact survivors of intimate partner violence (IPV) and make recommendations on how to revise the design of this feature to mitigate the potential harms found. The purpose of this research memo is to present my analysis on the current design of the location-sharing feature and recommendations to the design of the feature that will help prevent intimate partner abusers from misusing 200OK location sharing to abuse survivors.

SUMMARY

I recommend that our company revise the design of the location-sharing feature to better resist technology-enabled abuse. The current location-sharing feature allows users to tag photos they send to others with their location. Though convenient for users, this location-sharing feature may endanger survivors of intimate partner violence (IPV). This danger arises because an abuser may have access to the survivor's 200OK account because of their past or current intimate relationship [5]. An abuser with such access may be able to access this location data in order to surveil or stalk the survivor. This access may occur with or without the survivor's knowledge.

In order to prevent abuse enabled by 200OK's location-sharing feature, our company should (1) design the settings to be more accessible, (2) include a local override option, (3) notify users and log configuration changing events, and (4) document and create IPV resources about the location-sharing feature. By implementing these changes before the release of the location-sharing feature, our company can minimize the role the feature plays in harming survivors of IPV.

1. INTRODUCTION

Our company has decided to add a location-sharing feature to 200OK, our company's flagship product. 200OK is a communication app aimed at teenage and young adult users in the United States that blends classic instant messaging with photo sharing. By centering communication around sharing photos between two or more users, 200OK exceeds currently available messaging and social media applications in helping its users create seamless personal connections. In order to further increase user satisfaction, our company has decided to introduce a location-sharing feature to the app. Each time a user sends a photo to another user, this location-sharing feature automatically tags the photo with the location of the sending user. This location data will supplement the caption that usually accompanies a photo, resulting in an increased feeling of connection between the two users.

Because our company has not implemented a location-sharing feature in 200OK or other products before, I was asked to evaluate how this feature may impact survivors of intimate partner violence (IPV) and make recommendations on how to revise the design of this feature to mitigate the potential harms. Following the principles of abuse-resistant design, the recommendations in this memo will be used by our company to guide the process of improving the location-sharing feature design before it is launched. My research has found a number of areas for improvement in the design of the settings, in local overrides, in notification and logging options, and in the documentation and guidelines aspects of the feature.

Section 2 of this memo covers background on intimate partner violence, technology-enabled abuse, and stakeholders of this new feature. Section 3 of this memo analyzes and provides recommendations for the design of the location-sharing feature, and section 4 concludes the memo.

2. BACKGROUND

Understanding technology-enabled abuse is critical to properly evaluating and modifying the design of 200OK's location-sharing feature. Thus, intimate partner violence is described in section 2.1, technology-enabled abuse is described in section 2.2, and the stakeholders of this location-sharing feature are described in section 2.3.

2.1. Intimate Partner Violence

Intimate partner violence (IPV) is a significant public health concern and a shockingly prevalent experience in the United States. IPV is defined as any abuse, stalking, or aggression performed by a current or former dating partner or spouse and may include physical violence, sexual violence, stalking, or psychological aggression [1]. IPV is associated with mental health problems, such as depression and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD); negative risk behaviors, such as smoking and binge drinking; and physical health consequences, such as chronic pain. IPV may even result in death [1, 2].

Though commonly associated with violence against women in heterosexual relationships, experiencing IPV is not limited by a person's gender identity, sexual identity, or age: 47.3% women and 44.2% men in the United States report experiencing any contact sexual violence, physical violence, or stalking victimization by an intimate partner at some point in their lifetime [2]. Even though IPV can affect all ages, many survivors of IPV report first being victimized in their teens and twenties. Almost three quarters of female survivors of IPV and two-thirds of male survivors of IPV report being first victimized before age 25 [2]. The prevalence of IPV and the rate of early victimization is especially notable because 200OK's target audience is teenage and young adult users in the United States.

Stalking is a form of privacy violation that is associated with many of the same mental health problems as IPV. Stalking may include being followed, spied upon, or repeatedly contacted [3, 4]. Though stalking can occur inside or outside an intimate relationship, 43.4% of female survivors and 32.4% of male survivors were stalked by a current or former intimate partner [3]. Stalking within the context of an intimate relationship is often enabled by intimate partner surveillance (IPS), a subtle form of IPV that involves an abuser surveilling a survivor, usually by using technology. The location of a survivor, which can be collected from location sharing, can be used by an abuser for IPS and thus for IPV.

2.2. Technology-Enabled Abuse

The growing prevalence of technology in society has made communication more convenient but has also given abusers new means for controlling IPV survivors. Digital technologies play a nuanced role in IPV settings and can be weaponized by abusers to facilitate domestic abuse, stalking, and surveillance [5]. In particular, the increasing commoditization of abuse tools has given abusers easy access to a wide variety of tools designed to facilitate abuse [5, 6]. In addition to allowing abusers to exert greater control over IPV survivors, technology has also allowed abusers to connect with each other and trade information on how to abuse, occasionally even collaborating to create and refine new abuse tactics [4]. This collaboration and growing commoditization contributes to a constantly evolving technology-enabled abuse landscape that software engineering and IPV professionals must adapt to.

Though applications designed specifically for facilitating abuse are available for download on official app stores, legitimate apps can also be exploited by abusers to facilitate abuse. Digital location services, in particular, have been used by abusers to surveil and physically stalk survivors [7]. For example, family and child tracking apps such as "Find My Friends" and anti-theft apps such as "Find my iPhone" can be repurposed to monitor others without their knowledge or consent [5, 8]. These dual-use apps are designed for legitimate use cases but are used by an abuser to surveil, harass, or control a survivor's device, often without the survivor's knowledge [8]. Dual-use applications, though not intended to facilitate abuse, are a danger to survivors of IPV. An improperly-designed location-sharing feature risks transforming 200OK into a dual-use app.

2.3. Stakeholders

An overview of the various stakeholders of 200OK’s location-sharing feature is given in section 2.3.1. Following this overview is a discussion of IPV survivors, abusers, and professionals, who are described in sections 2.3.2, 2.3.3, and 2.3.4, respectively.

2.3.1 The IPV Ecosystem

The IPV ecosystem is complex: it encompasses not only the abuser and survivor, but also shared friends, family, and children, and a network of professionals designed to support a survivor. As shown in Figure 1, IPV professionals include both those working directly with IPV cases and those working in the education, legal, mental health, and housing industries. An abuse-resistant design for the 200OK should be easy for survivors and IPV professionals to use but difficult for abusers to misuse. Thus, the wide variety of stakeholders in the IPV ecosystem must be considered when evaluating the design of the location-sharing feature.

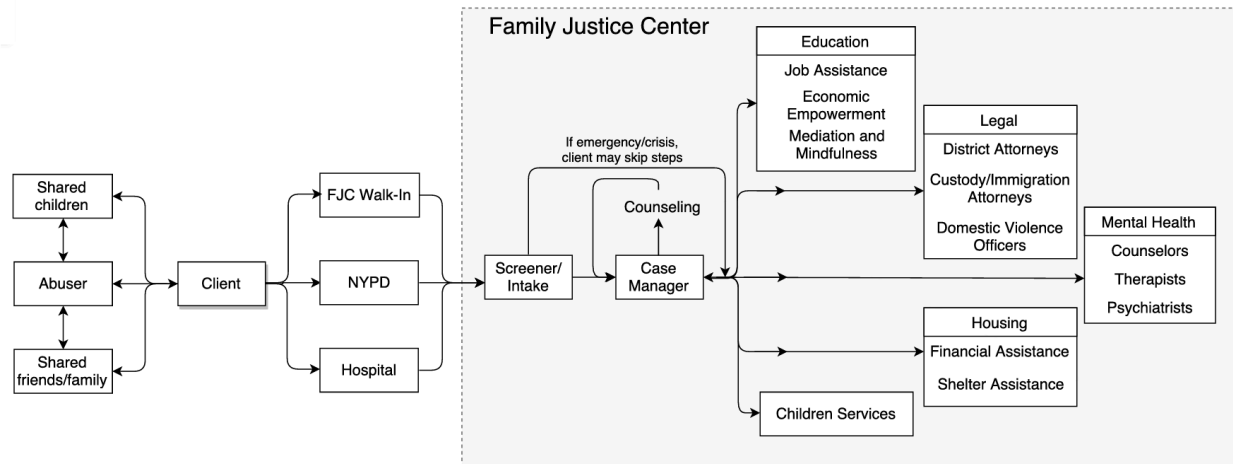


Figure 1: The IPV ecosystem for survivors (called clients in the figure) in New York City consists of diverse stakeholders [5].

2.3.2 Survivors of Intimate Partner Violence

Survivors of intimate partner violence are diverse: they come from different cultural, educational, socioeconomic, and technical backgrounds. However, Freed et al. (2017) found that many survivors explicitly describe themselves as lacking technical expertise, especially in understanding if or how technology plays a role in their abuse. Survivors also frequently lack a nuanced understanding of privacy settings in social computing platforms and thus are unable to properly understand who is able to access what information about them. Furthermore, in many IPV settings, the abuser has greater technical expertise than the survivor [5]. A lack of confidence in technical skills combined with a more technically savvy abuser contributes to feelings of fear and helplessness in survivors.

2.3.3 Intimate Partner Abusers

Defending against intimate partner abusers poses a unique challenge because the abuser and survivor share or have shared an intimate relationship and often continue to be socially entangled through shared friends or children. As a result, the abuser is frequently able to gain access to a survivor’s devices and online accounts [5]. This access may be gained from survivors’ willingly sharing passwords before abuse began, from abusers manipulating, guilt-tripping or forcing survivors to hand over devices or passwords, or from abusers correctly guessing security questions using knowledge of the survivor to reset an online account password [4, 5]. Abusers may also install spyware on a survivor’s phone, exploit data back-up services to a shared cloud, or outsource attacks by paying others to stalk or harass a survivor [4, 6, 9].

In addition to having intimate knowledge and access to a survivor’s devices and online accounts, the abuser may have also bought the device used by the survivor or share a cellular family plan with the survivor. Such ownership gives the abuser the ability to control and track devices, and by extension, the survivor [5]. Thus, an abuser is commonly an authorized instead of unauthorized user of a piece of technology. An abuser appears to be a regular user to the device or application. These abusers can be thought of as an UI-bound adversary: an authenticated but adversarial user who carries out attacks through the standard user interface [6]. Most abusers are UI-bound.

However, some abusers demonstrate a high level of technical expertise. Tseng et al. (2020) analyzed infidelity forums for behavior encouraging or demonstrating IPS and IPV, and found that some threads explained how to use sophisticated techniques such as custom shell scripts and DNS resolution tools to surveil and control a partner’s Internet browsing [4]. These forums served as guides and one-on-one support for less technically-savvy abusers, highlighting the possibility for an abuser to execute attacks beyond their expected technical expertise.

2.3.4 Intimate Partner Violence Professionals

Many IPV professionals are constrained by their technical expertise. Freed et al. (2017) interviewed 40 IPV professionals in New York City: though these professionals had varying levels of technology expertise, none had formal education or extensive work experience in a technology-related field. Thus, when working on IPV cases, many professionals described themselves as frequently “Google[ing]-as-they-go” and using online IPV-specific technical guides, which may be out of date, vague, or non-existent if a website or app is less well-established [5]. Thus, even though IPV professionals work with many technology-enabled abuse cases, they still face technical challenges when helping survivors.

3. LOCATION FEATURE EVALUATION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Using the descriptions of IPV survivors, abusers, and professionals, section 3.1 evaluates the design of the 200OK location-sharing feature. Section 3.2 provides concrete recommendations on how to improve the design detailed in section 3.1.

3.1 Evaluation of Design

To establish a common understanding of the current design of the location-sharing feature, section 3.1.1 describes the design of the feature in detail. Section 3.1.2 points out several ways an abuser may use the location-sharing feature, as currently designed, for abuse.

3.1.1 Description of Design

Our current location-sharing feature is designed such that each time a user sends a photo to another user, the location-sharing feature automatically tags the photo with the location of the sending user. This location data will supplement the caption that usually accompanies a photo, resulting in an increased feeling of connection between the two users. In order to view the locations of photos sent in the past, a user can reference the photo thread they have with another user. A photo thread between two users displays past photos and allows a user to click on a photo in the thread. After being clicked, the photo will be displayed in full screen with its associated caption and location. Senders are able to unsend a photo and all associated data if the recipient has not opened the photo.

This location-sharing feature's options can be configured in 200OK's settings. 200OK's settings are accessible through both the 200OK mobile app and by logging into 200OK's web interface through a browser. Specifically, the configuration options in both the mobile app and web interface for this feature are located in My Profile → Settings → Messaging → Location Sharing. Users of 200OK have three location-sharing options to choose from: share location with no one, share location with everyone, and share location with select users. As shown in Figure 2, if users choose the third option, then a "Sharing To" button pops up: clicking on this button allows users to specify and view which users have access to their location when sending photos. Location sharing is turned off by default for all users, and there are no notifications or user-facing logging information associated with location-sharing configuration changes.

Because the location-sharing feature adds locations to individual photos in a photo thread, this location data is stored with the associated photo and caption. As a result, this location data is backed up when photo threads are backed up. Photo threads can be backed up manually or automatically to a third-party cloud service such as Google Drive or iCloud. 200OK also allows users to export photo threads to a device.

Similar to the location-sharing feature options, backup options can be configured in 200OK's settings. Specifically, the configuration options in both the mobile app and web interface for backups are located in My Profile → Settings → My Data → Backups. A user can choose to backup or export one or more photo threads to a third-party cloud service or to the device. Automatic backups to a third-party cloud service can also be scheduled. If a photo thread is backed up, all photos and associated captions and locations are backed up together. Backups are turned off by default, and there are no notifications or user-facing logging information associated with backing up location information.

Location Sharing

Share location with:

No one

Everyone

Select users

Ami Vu

Derek Chan

Ellie Smith

Jung Verith

Figure 2: A 200OK user can choose from three location-sharing options: sharing with no one, everyone, or select users. The select users option gives a user fine-grained control over who has access to their location data.

3.1.2 Potential for Abuse in Design

The introduction of location-sharing feature makes 200OK a potential dual use app that can be exploited by abusers to control survivors. Specifically, the location-sharing feature makes it possible for an abuser to track a survivor’s precise location each time the survivor communicates with the abuser or with another user. Such location information allows abusers to conduct IPS and stalking and may exacerbate other types of IPV.

An abuser can gain a survivor’s location data directly when the survivor sends an abuser a photo if the survivor is sharing their location with the abuser. Similar to how an abuser gains access to a survivor’s devices or online accounts, the abuser may have convinced the survivor to turn on location sharing with them when the relationship was “good” or manipulate, guilt-trip or force a survivor to do so. An abuser who is more technically-savvy than the survivor may also be able to gain access to a survivor’s 200OK account and turn on location sharing for themselves. Crucially, the act of turning on location sharing may go unnoticed by the survivor because 200OK does not send any notifications regarding location-sharing configuration changes.

In addition to gaining location data directly from the location-sharing feature, an abuser could access location data indirectly through backups. An abuser who has access to a survivor’s 200OK account could manually export photo threads between the survivor and a user who has location sharing turned on to the device, which the abuser may own, in order to view location data. Similarly, an abuser could also backup these photo threads to a cloud account that they control and configure 200OK to perform these backups regularly. These attacks would allow an abuser to gain one-time or regular access to a survivor’s location data, even if the survivor is not sharing location data with the abuser directly. Notably, even a survivor who is familiar with the

location-sharing feature and is consciously not sharing their location with their abuser may be unaware that their abuser continues to have access to their location through 200OK. The inconspicuousness of such an attack is especially concerning.

In addition to allowing an abuser to surveil a survivor without the survivor noticing, the lack of notifications and logging for actions that impact location data may lead to gaslighting. An abuser who can hide or remove evidence of an action taking place, such as accessing location data, can manipulate a survivor into thinking they are not actually being surveilled [9]. In such situations the survivor is made to believe that they are paranoid or overly sensitive rather than a victim of abuse. Gaslighting can contribute increased distress in survivors and complicate aid and recovery efforts.

3.2 Recommendations for Design

To make 200OK more resistant to technology-enabled abuse, the application should follow principles for abuse-resistant design, as described in section 3.2.1. Following this section, I give four actionable recommendations for redesigning 200OK: (1) redesign the settings, which is covered in section 3.2.2; (2) include a local override option for location sharing, which is covered in section 3.2.3; (3) add notifications and logging, which is covered in section 3.2.4; and (4) document the feature and create an IPV Guide, which is covered in section 3.2.5.

3.2.1. Principles for Abuse-Resistant Design

In situations where a piece of technology is suspected to play a role in abuse or surveillance, common recommendations include deleting the application, switching devices, or even disconnecting completely from technology. However, these actions can cut off survivors from support systems and result in an escalation of abuse [5]. Galperin, a cybersecurity and technology-enabled abuse expert, argues that predicting abuser behavior and escalation is difficult, so leaving decisions up to the survivor should be a priority [10]. Instead of making decisions for a user, abuse-resistant design should guarantee privacy and choice, be intuitive to use, and clearly communicate to users what activity has occurred on the account and what information is being shared with who [9, 11]. By following these overarching principles, 200OK can revise the location-sharing feature to be more resistant to technology-enabled abuse.

3.2.2. Redesign the Settings

The current design of 200OK's settings is complex and obscure to IPV survivors. Such a design may prevent survivors from making informed choices about the location sharing and backups. Daffalla et al. (2023) note that account security interfaces (ASIs) play a key role in IPV survivor safety by allowing survivors to identify likely compromises by their abuser [11]. ASIs, often found in the settings, allow a user to control or monitor access to an online account. These interfaces commonly include device lists, which detail devices that are authorized to access an account; session lists, which detail currently active or terminated sessions; and activity logs, which detail recent security activity on an account. However, survivors often hesitate to make

security changes because they are uncertain about the impact of potential configuration changes or unaware that they can make these changes in the first place [11]. Complex or multiple navigation flows act as an extra barrier to user choice, and users intimidated by privacy options in settings can cause them to pick the default setting [9].

Thus, making 200OK's settings easier to navigate and understand is especially important for helping IPV survivors to make informed choices about location data. Currently, four steps are required to navigate to both location-sharing and backup configuration options. I suggest that our company shorten the number of steps needed to access these configuration options for location sharing and backups to two and three, respectively. Specifically, I suggest that location-sharing options be accessed by Settings → Location Sharing and backup options be accessed by Settings → My Data → Backups. Reducing the number of steps required to access location-sharing and backup configuration options will help survivors find these options more quickly and easily.

Survivors should be empowered to make informed changes about their settings. 200OK's current design turns off location sharing and backups by default: while these defaults are a wise choice for most IPV situations, certain IPV situations may call for different settings. Thus, I recommend that our company includes short descriptions of what each location-sharing and backup option entails directly in the settings. These descriptions will allow survivors to better understand how 200OK will change if they choose different configuration options. Such a design will allow survivors to gain the technical confidence needed to decide how their location data is shared without requiring them to read online documentation or forums.

3.2.3 Include a Local Override for Location Sharing

In addition to making the options for location sharing and backups easier to find and understand, I recommend that a local override option be present when a message is sent. Cybersecurity expert Nuttall notes that local overrides empower users with the ability to choose to retain control of their environment [9]. This local location-sharing override option, which will consist of a checkbox next to the send photo button, will allow users to choose whether a photo about to be sent includes a location or not on a case-by-case basis. This option gives survivors who do not know how to configure location sharing through their settings the option to share or not share their location. An override option also transfers location-sharing control from a user who has access to login credentials to the user who sends a photo: an abuser may have access to login credentials, but the survivor is the one who sends messages. Whether the checkbox is checked by default or not will be determined by the configuration options in settings in order to minimize the override's impact on users outside of an IPV setting.

3.2.4. Add Notifications and Logging

Built-in functionality that is transparent about what changes have been made makes it more difficult for abusers to gaslight survivors about their abuse. Both notifications and logging are essential for countering gaslighting, yet 200OK currently lacks notifications and logging for actions that impact location data. Thus, 200OK should send in-app notifications and notifications via email when location-sharing and backup configurations are changed. This policy, resembling how Google notifies users via email when suspicious account activity is detected, will help a

survivor detect if another person, such as their abuser, is modifying their location-sharing or backup configurations in the settings of their account [11]. In line with Nuttall's recommendations, 200OK should also include periodic notifications for users, prompting them to review location-sharing and backup configurations [9]. Lastly, 200OK should regularly inform the user that they are syncing sensitive location data to the cloud if they have automatic backups turned on [8]. These notifications will help IPV survivors stay informed about activity related to location data on their account.

In addition to notifications, 200OK should also include logs, accessible in the settings, that detail when and how location and backup configurations have been changed. These logs will allow IPV survivors and professionals to view behavior on the account and detect whether an abuser is modifying configuration options related to location data. Notably, these activity logs would also be visible to the abuser if they have logged into the account: thus, these logs should be an optional feature [11]. Because logging has a tradeoff with privacy, these logs should only be kept for a limited period of time that is determined by the user. Logging configuration changes related to location data will give IPV survivors a more enduring record if an abuser modifies their location-sharing or backup configuration.

3.2.5. Document the Feature and Create an IPV Guide

Documenting how the location-sharing feature works provides a valuable resource for IPV survivors and professionals to reference when using 200OK. Daffalla et al. (2023) note that different software platforms often confuse IPV survivors when they use different terminology to refer to the same concepts in account security interfaces [11]. By better defining the vocabulary used in 200OK settings, IPV survivors and professionals can accurately understand how different configuration options will change how 200OK functions. Lastly, many services lack formal documentation on the lifetime of logs [11]. Our documentation should include how long location-sharing change logs are kept by default and how users can change this timeframe.

In addition to clear documentation, our company should also consider creating an IPV-specific guide for 200OK. Such a guide would communicate what configuration options and features in 200OK may be especially relevant for IPV settings and would serve as a valuable reference for IPV survivors and professionals. The guide should include actionable advice that clearly communicates what an IPV survivor may need to know, such as how to change a password or change the recovery phone number associated with the account. In addition to such general how-tos, the guide should also suggest courses of action. For the location-sharing feature, specific courses of action could include how to turn on and off the location sharing with specific users and how to view which users have access to a user's location. Furthermore, the guide should remind survivors that certain actions, such as turning off location sharing to an abuser, may be noticed by the abuser. Such actionable advice equips a survivor with the knowledge needed to change the settings of 200OK and understand the possible ramifications of those changes.

4. CONCLUSION

IPV is a significant public health concern that affects many of 200OK's users. The location-sharing feature that is aimed to be introduced into 200OK currently has multiple design shortcomings that may allow an abuser to view the location data of a survivor without their awareness. This location data can be used by an abuser to surveil the survivor. Thus, our company should revise the location-sharing feature by (1) designing the settings to be more accessible, (2) including a local override option, (3) notifying users and logging configuration changing events, and (4) documenting and creating IPV resources about the location-sharing feature. With careful and intentional design choices, our company can reduce the likelihood of abusers exploiting 200OK's new location-sharing feature to abuse survivors.

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